

Session 16: Worry and Wealth

Key Takeaways

- Jesus teaches us to shift our mental focus from excessive concern about wealth and security to trusting God and seeking to do right by him.
- The Greek word *merimnao*, often translated as “worry,” can be positive or negative and deals with what we “have concern for.” It is not equivalent to a modern understanding of clinical anxiety.
- This wisdom is difficult, but Jesus models the lifestyle he teaches. He has no home or possessions, and his path leads to (and through) death, but he faithfully trusts his Father in the skies with his whole life.

Do Not Worry

25 Because of this I say to y'all,

- a **do not worry** about your **life-being** ,
b what you will **eat** or what you will **drink** ;
a' not even about your **body** ,
b' what you will **put on** .

Isn't the **living-being** more than **food** ,
and the **body** more than **clothing** ?

- a 26 **Look at the birds of the air** ,
how they don't sow seed ,
and they don't harvest ,
and they don't gather into barns ;

A

- b and yet **your Father in the skies** **feeds** **them** .

- a' Aren't you all **much more** valuable than **they** ?

- B 27 And who among you is able to add an hour to your life-span by **worry** ?

a 28 And about **clothing**, why are you all **worrying**?

Pay attention to the lilies of the field,
how they grow .
They don't labor ,
and they don't weave cloth ;

A' b 29 but I say to you all,
that not even Solomon in all his honor **clothed** himself like **one of these**.

a' 30 Now, if **the grass of the field**,
which is there today and tomorrow is tossed into the furnace,
is **clothed** this way by God,
won't he **much more** **clothe** you all, who have so little trust?!

A 31 So then, **don't worry**, saying,
"What will we **eat**?"
or "What will we **drink**?"
or "What will we wear for **clothing**?"

B 32 For the nations, they constantly **seek for** **all these-things**,
for **your Father in the skies** knows that you need **all that**.
33 Rather, first **seek** for **the Kingdom of God**
and **doing-right by him**,
and **all these-things** will be added to you.

A' 34 So then, **don't worry** about tomorrow.
Tomorrow can **worry** about itself!
Each day has enough trouble of its own.

Matthew 6:25-34. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

These sayings go back to the opening contrast between "treasure on the land or in the sky." If one's sense of security is based on earthly treasure, Jesus probes into the inner-psychology and experience of basing one's trust on such things. It produces a lot of anxiety.

Freedom from anxiety is rooted in a conception of the universe: that it is a safe place where I'm welcomed by a generous host. The overabundance I see in nature comes from a creator who shows that same generosity towards me. This mindset is what frees me from a scarcity mindset to release resources to others.

What kind of tradition forms a person to speak like this? (You can't just say, "Well, he's Jesus!") How is a person formed who looks at birds and flowers and grass and sees signs of God's generosity and overabundant love? These words sound almost irresponsible to Type-A, hardworking people. With these words, Jesus is articulating a way of seeing the world that is rooted in Hebrew Scriptures and their depiction of God's generosity.

There are also the wise sayings in Proverbs about saving up enough money so that one has provision in the day of need.

Proverbs 6:6–11 NASB

⁶ Go to the ant, O sluggard,
observe her ways and be wise,
⁷ which, having no chief,
officer or ruler,
⁸ prepares her food in the summer
and gathers her provision in the harvest.
⁹ How long will you lie down, O sluggard?
When will you arise from your sleep?
¹⁰ "A little sleep, a little slumber,
a little folding of the hands to rest"—
¹¹ your poverty will come in like a vagabond
and your need like an armed man.

Proverbs 24:30–34 NASB

³⁰ I passed by the field of the sluggard
and by the vineyard of the man lacking sense,
³¹ and behold, it was completely overgrown with thistles;
its surface was covered with nettles,
and its stone wall was broken down.
³² When I saw, I reflected upon it;
I looked, and received instruction.
³³ "A little sleep, a little slumber,
a little folding of the hands to rest,"
³⁴ then your poverty will come as a robber
and your want like an armed man.

Proverbs 10:5 NASB

He who gathers in summer is a son who acts wisely,
but he who sleeps in harvest is a son who acts shamefully.

Proverbs 20:4 NASB

The sluggard does not plow after the autumn,
so he begs during the harvest and has nothing.

Psalms 104:10–17 LEB

¹⁰ **You are the one who sends** forth springs into the valleys;
they flow between the mountains.

¹¹ They give drink for every beast of the field.
The wild donkeys [quench] their thirst.

¹² Along them **the birds of the heavens** abide.
From among the branches they [sing].

¹³ **You are the one who [waters]** the mountains
from his upper chambers.
The earth is full with the fruit of your labors:

¹⁴ **who causes** grass to grow for the cattle
and herbs for the service of humankind,
to bring forth food from the earth,

¹⁵ and wine that makes glad the heart of man,
so that their faces shine from oil,
and bread that strengthens the heart of man.

¹⁶ **The trees of Yahweh** drink their fill,
the cedars of Lebanon that he planted,

¹⁷ where birds make their nest.

The stork has its home in the fir trees.

Worry or Anxiety or What?

The Greek word used for “worry” here is the verb *merimnao* (μεριμνάω), related to the noun “worry” (*merimna* / μέριμνα). These words appear 25 times in the New Testament and have a wider range of meaning than the English word “worry.”

The word *merimna* can have a positive meaning, in the sense of “concern” that is appropriate and good.

Philippians 2:19–20 NASB*

But I hope in the Lord Jesus to send Timothy to you shortly, so that I also may be encouraged when I learn of your condition. For I have no one else of kindred spirit who will genuinely be **merimnao** for your welfare.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Corinthians 12:25 NASB*

so that there may be no division in the body, but that the members may have the same **merimna** for one another.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Corinthians 11:28 NASB*

Apart from such external things, there is the daily pressure on me of **merimna** for all the churches.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The word *merimna* can also have a negative effect, steering the mind into a posture of fear and anxiety.

Philippians 4:6–7 NIV*

Do not be **merimnao** about anything, but in every situation, by prayer and petition, with thanksgiving, present your requests to God. And the peace of God, which transcends all understanding, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Matthew 10:18–19 NASB*

and you will even be brought before governors and kings for my sake, as a testimony to them and to the Gentiles. But when they hand you over, do not **merimnao** about how or what you are to say; for it will be given you in that hour what you are to say.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Luke 8:14 NASB*

The seed which fell among the thorns, these are the ones who have heard, and as they go on their way they are choked with **merimna** and riches and pleasures of this life, and bring no fruit to maturity.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Luke 21:34 NIV*

Be careful, or your hearts will be weighed down with carousing, drunkenness and the **merimna** of life, and that day will close on you suddenly like a trap.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

So the act of showing concern is not negative in and of itself. Rather, good concern develops into unhealthy concern depending on the degree and the object of our concern. Notice how Paul uses the flexibility of this word in the same paragraph.

1 Corinthians 7:32–34 NASB*

But I want you to be free from *merimna*. One who is unmarried is **merimnao** about the things of the Lord, how he may please the Lord; but one who is married is **merimnao** about the things of the world, how he may please his wife, and his interests are divided. The woman who is unmarried, and the virgin, is **merimnao** about the things of the Lord, that she may be holy both in body and spirit; but one who is married is **merimnao** about the things of the world, how she may please her husband.

Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reflection Question

What does Jesus mean when he tells us, “Do not worry,” in [Matthew 6:25-34](#)?